

China Economic Perspectives

AI is reshaping China's trade story – upgrading 2026 trade forecasts

Economics

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AI has emerged as a key driver of China's trade

China's trade performance has consistently exceeded market expectations in 2026, with exports recording 18% YoY and imports 26% in 1H. We believe AI-related trade is the main driver, contributing nearly half of total export and import growth in 1H. The strength has been driven more by prices than volumes, reflecting an undersupplied market and product upgrading. A significant portion of China's AI trade is conducted with neighbouring economies in the region, facilitating both imports and exports and underscoring China's deeper integration into the global tech supply chain.

Resilience extends beyond AI

Non-AI exports rose 11% YoY in 1H, driven by strong overseas sales of green products (batteries, solar, power equipment, etc.) as well as a surge in auto shipments, particularly EVs and hybrid vehicles. Consumer goods exports failed to match this momentum. Non-AI imports jumped 19% YoY led by gold, oil and other commodities, all supported by price increases. We expect this price tailwind to fade later in 2026.

Upgrade 2026 trade growth forecasts

Reflecting sustained AI-led export strength and resilience elsewhere, we now expect exports to grow around 18% in 2026 in nominal USD terms. The strong AI-related exports should boost related imports, while non-AI imports may soften partly as commodity price growth decelerates. We therefore raise our 2026 import forecast to 24%. Excluding price effects, we expect net exports to contribute 0.8ppt to real GDP growth, notably smaller than 1.6ppt in 2025, highlighting the need to stabilize domestic growth. Key risks include the strength of the global AI cycle, commodity price swings, trade policy changes, and domestic growth momentum.

Macro and policy implications

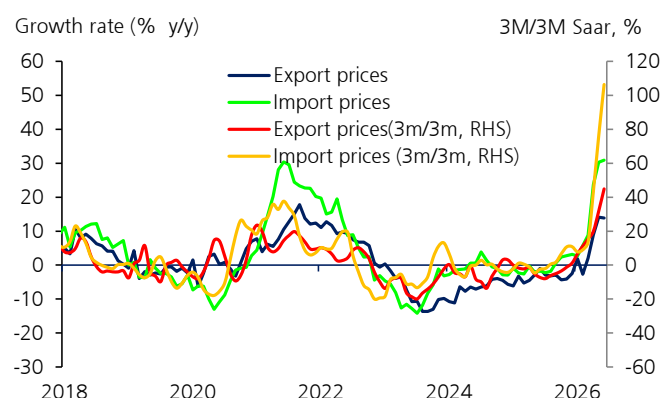
Despite strong exports and AI-related wealth effects, [domestic weakening in 2Q](#) points to a likely policy shift. In our view, any incremental demand for global commodities is more likely to come from AI and related infrastructure investment than from a strong rebound in China's property sector. Export prices have started to rebound in 2026 after falling 17% over the past three years, led by tech products and domestic reflation. This may ease concerns about exported deflation, but could add to global inflation pressures in selected areas. Import prices are rising even faster, further eroding China's terms of trade. Even so, the RMB has remained resilient, with the PBoC allowing gradual appreciation, potentially as a signal of confidence and to help ease trade tensions.

China's trade momentum has been surprisingly strong so far in 2026. Exports grew 17.6% YoY in the first half of 2026, while imports jumped 26% YoY, both far outpacing expectations. Stronger-than-expected export growth occurred despite renminbi appreciation against the US dollar (3% in 1H) and on a trade-weighted basis (NEER +5.5%, REER +3.1% in 1H).

This strength is largely price-related: export prices have bounced since early 2026 and increased by 6.5% YoY in 1H, while import prices surged by 18%. Both have been supported by a significant increase in tech product prices along with higher commodity prices across the board, not least crude oil. After adjusting for price effects, real export growth was largely stable at 10% YoY YTD (vs a 9.4% increase in 2025). Real imports rose notably by 9% (vs only a 0.5% increase last year), with momentum jumping in 1Q before softening in 2Q.

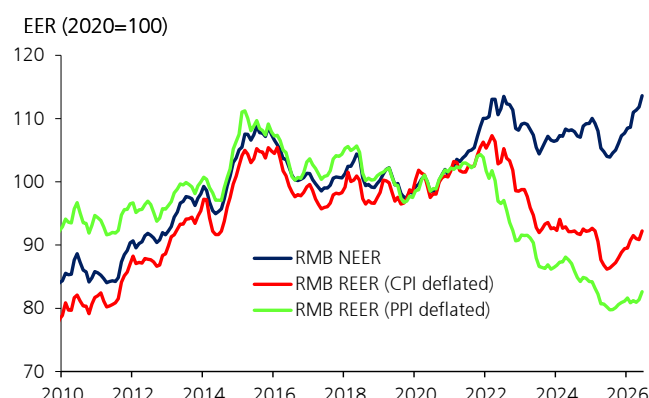
In this note, we examine the underlying sources of strength, identify the key growth drivers, and evaluate the sustainability of these trends.

Figure 1: Price increase explains a large portion of trade strength YTD



Source: CEIC, UBS estimates

Figure 2: RMB strengthened in EER terms



Source: Haver, UBS estimates

AI trade has emerged as a key driver

The global AI boom has become a pivotal force behind China's trade upswing.

Over the past few years, the rapid development and deployment of AI worldwide have reshaped tech supply chains. China is now increasingly integrated into the AI hardware ecosystem and, as a large hardware-components supplier, is benefiting from these tailwinds.

To quantify this, we define "AI-related" goods using two reference lists: a [WTO AI-enabling list](#) (104 HS6 products), and a broader list from [NBER](#) (665 items at HS10 level). Both approaches show exceptional growth: AI-related exports grew a robust 40-47% YoY YTD, while AI-related imports grew by 44-47% YoY. Because differences between US and Chinese trade codes complicate mapping at the HS10 level, **we primarily rely on the narrower WTO list.**

Most of China's AI exports are intermediate inputs, with integrated circuits (ICs) at the core.

Under the WTO definition, over three-quarters of China's AI exports are intermediate inputs and the rest are mostly equipment, while China exports very little chemicals or raw materials. The AI export basket features ICs, computer parts and components, communications equipment (e.g., optical modules), printed circuit boards (PCBs), data storage devices, power equipment and more. While micro-level observations suggest some products are tailored specifically for AI usage such as optical components and PCBs, a large portion consists of mature-node chips also used in automobiles or industrial manufacturing that fall on the WTO list of AI-enabling products. This could overstate the AI-specific contribution.

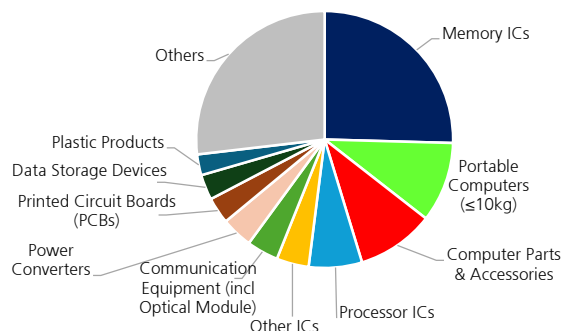
China's AI trade is deeply embedded in global supply chains, especially Asia.

Over 70% of the trade is connected with other Asian economies. Hong Kong is the top export destination with most of the shipments likely re-exported to other destinations - overall re-exports consistently account for more than 98% of Hong Kong's merchandise exports even though detailed re-export data for AI-related products are unavailable. Vietnam, Korea and Taiwan are the top three export destinations within Asia, taking a quarter of the AI exports directly, reflecting China's ties with other major AI exporters and the Asian supply chain.

On the import side, chips dominate: more than 60% of AI-related imports are various semiconductors (memory, processors and amplifiers), alongside advanced computer components, data storage units, and semiconductor fabrication equipment. A large share of China's AI exports is "processing trade", which inherently relies on imported components at earlier stages of production.

Figure 3: AI exports cover a broad mix of tech hardware

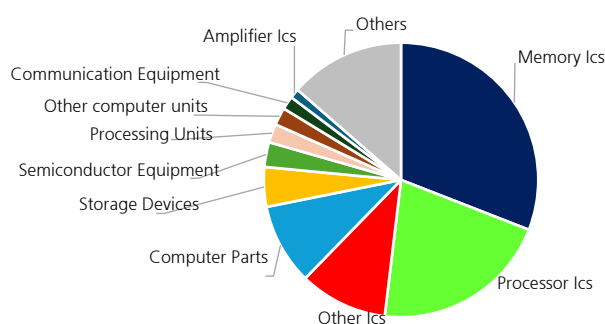
China's AI exports (1H 2026)



Source: CEIC, WTO, China Customs, UBS estimates

Figure 4: AI imports are dominated by ICs

China's AI Imports (1H 2026)

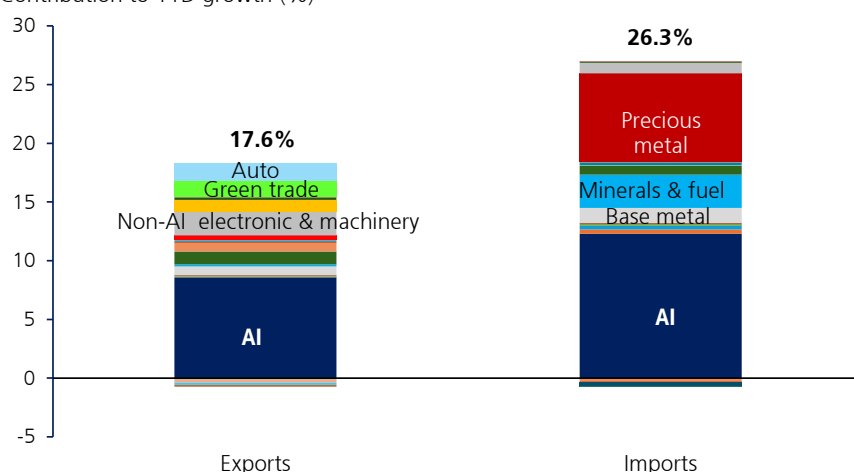


Source: CEIC, WTO, China Customs, UBS estimates

AI-related products already make up nearly half of trade growth in 2026. In the first half, approximately 23% of China's total exports and 30% of its imports were AI-related, marking a notable increase from 17% and 22% in 2023, respectively. Both imports and exports of AI related products have grown robustly by 47% YoY YTD, contributing around half of overall export/import growth (49%/47%, respectively).

Figure 5: AI products contributed 49% of export growth and 47% of import growth in 1H

Contribution to YTD growth (%)



Source: CEIC, WTO, China Customs, UBS estimates

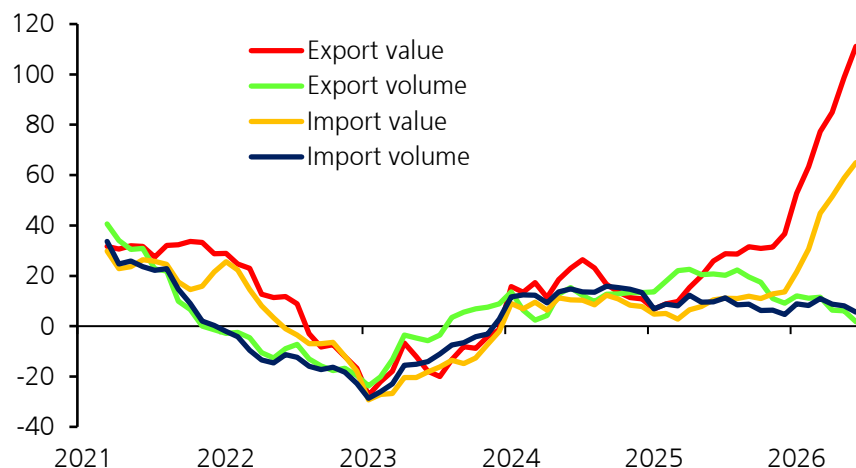
The AI trade boom is mainly a nominal price story rather than a volume cycle.

The rise in AI trade is much more reliant on price changes than previous cycles. Take electronic integrated circuits as an example. China's exports of electronic ICs jumped by an impressive 96% YoY in 1H in value terms, but volumes crept up by only 6% YoY and

they have decelerated lately (in units). The slowdown in volume terms likely reflects a combination of base effects and softer demand in some submarkets. On the import side, values climbed 56% YoY but volumes increased by just 8% YoY. Prices drove much of the growth. The sharp price increase reflects AI-driven demand in a supply-constrained market, with capacity shifting toward high-end AI-related products, tightening supply elsewhere and pushing up tech product prices more broadly. Changes in product content per export/import unit may also have lifted average selling prices.

Figure 6: Price surge has been a major driver

Electronic Integrated circuits trade (%y/y 3mma)



Source: CEIC, UBS estimates

Can China's AI trade boom last?

AI Capex will likely expand further in the coming quarters based on the UBS tech team's projections (see [here](#)). The UBS team foresees an unprecedented memory upcycle, with DRAM/NAND undersupply lasting into 2Q28/4Q27. On pricing, they estimate that Long Term Agreements (LTAs) could fix c. 20-30% of total industry volumes and pricing for the next 2-3 years (see [here](#)). Additionally, with demand continuing to far outstrip supply, they forecast ex-LTA DDR contract pricing to rise +32% QoQ in 3Q26 and +18% QoQ in 4Q26, after +67% QoQ in 2Q26; and for NAND they forecast pricing up +30% QoQ in 3Q and +12% QoQ in 4Q after +67% QoQ also in 2Q (see [here](#)). Consequently, the YoY growth is likely to peak around mid-2026 and slow later in the year, nonetheless to an elevated level. Export prices for China's major tech products will continue to benefit in the near term.

On the external demand side, given China's existing scale of production and early connection to the supply chain, we expect China's manufacturers to continue to benefit from further global AI Capex expansion and other tech-related demand. **On the import side**, a substantial portion of China's tech imports are processing inputs destined for further processing before re-exports, so booming AI exports mechanically drive AI imports. The relaxation of import bottlenecks in 2026 – for example, the US approval of sales of Nvidia H200 AI chips to some Chinese firms after President Trump's visit – offers some relief for domestic data centres to access advanced GPUs, but we believe this falls short of a breakthrough (see [here](#)).

Looking further ahead, the medium-term challenge is how much China can continue moving up the value chain. China's existing industry scale offers China the early advantage to be a large hardware components supplier, but currently the most advanced AI infrastructure in global trade, such as GPUs and HBMs, are dominated by other economies. In addition, China's access to advanced semiconductor manufacturing equipment is constrained. Thus, there could be limited further market share gains and domestic value-added gains in the medium term.

Resilience Beyond AI

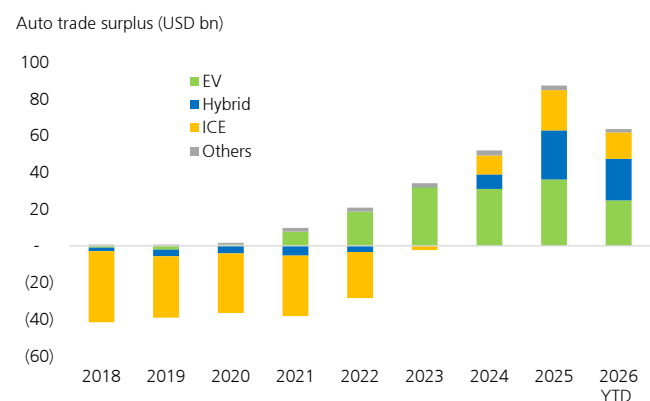
Beyond the rapidly growing AI-linked sectors, other exports have also held up well. Non-AI exports expanded by 11% YoY in 1H26.

Autos remain an important source of resilience. China's auto export growth accelerated to 60% YoY in 1H, driven by hybrid vehicles (115% YoY) and EVs (57% YoY). The appeal of EVs has strengthened further in 2026 amid energy transition trends and after the Middle East conflict. Since becoming a net car exporter in 2023, Chinese automakers are projected to capture one-third of global market share by 2030 ([UBSe](#)), leveraging advanced EV technology and expanding international presence.

Green trade has become another key growth engine, supported by electrification and infrastructure demand. "Green exports", including batteries, solar, wind, electrical equipment, and optical fiber, expanded 31% YoY in 1H26 (vs 15% in 2025), contributing 8% to headline export growth. In particular, battery exports climbed 40% YoY, solar equipment 24%, and electrical equipment 24%. Heightened urgency for electrification and resilient infrastructure—particularly post-Middle East conflict—has boosted demand for China's green technologies, supported by their cost competitiveness, improving product quality, and proven manufacturing scale. However, future growth will hinge on policy shifts in key markets, especially Europe, China's largest customer (see [UBS ESG team's note](#) and [monthly tracker](#); note the analysis excludes products overlapped with AI list), as well as China's own policies such as the removal of export VAT rebates for solar.

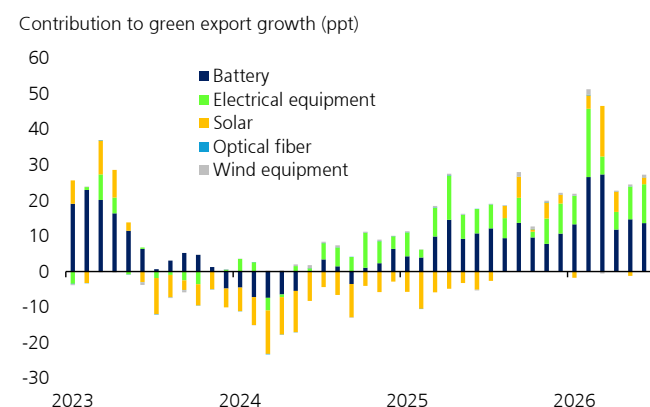
Traditional consumer goods exports remained weak. Categories like textiles and apparel (up 1.4% YoY in 1H), footwear and hats (-5%), furniture and lighting (0.6%), and toys and sporting goods (-12%) have struggled, reflecting muted global consumer demand amid persistent inflation. In June, exports of furniture and home appliances accelerated significantly, possibly reflecting increased demand related to heatwaves (see [June reading](#)). Thus, robust export growth YTD has been mainly driven by tech and industrial demand, while traditional goods have lagged behind.

Figure 7: China has shifted from a net auto importer to an exporter



Source: CEIC, China Customs, UBS estimates

Figure 8: Green exports gained momentum in 2026



Source: CEIC, China Customs, UBS estimates

Non-AI import strength does not signal a broad domestic-demand rebound. China's non-AI imports grew 19% YoY in 1H, with precious metals (particularly gold) and commodities standing out. In our view, the strength mainly reflects price gains, selective industrial demand, and financial investment demand, rather than a broad-based recovery in domestic activity.

Price effects lifted import values. In 1H26, import prices rose 38% YoY for copper ore and 36% for unwrought copper, 20% for crude oil and 24% for petroleum products, while iron ore prices increased 5%. This explains a meaningful share of headline import strength, suggesting value growth should not be read as a broad volume rebound.

Import volumes of key commodities were mixed. Crude oil is the clearest example: during the 2Q price spike following Middle East tensions, volumes fell -30% YoY (9% in Q1) and -76% QoQ Saar (-5% in Q1). This likely reflected weaker downstream demand, as seen in lower chemical-sector utilization (until signs of SOE utilization improvements in the [week of July 20](#)), combined with inventory drawdowns in downstream sectors on expectations that the oil shock would prove temporary. Among industrial commodity imports, copper ore volumes were broadly flat YoY, unwrought copper fell 5% YoY, and iron ore held up at 6% YoY. On a seasonally adjusted basis, copper ore volumes declined 12% QoQ Saar (0% in Q1), while iron ore edged up 4% (-21% in Q1). In our view, real commodity demand is increasingly tied to electrification, EVs, power infrastructure, and export-oriented manufacturing. With property new starts still trending lower through 2Q, a property-led restocking cycle remains absent, despite policy easing and [signs of sales recovery in some cities](#).

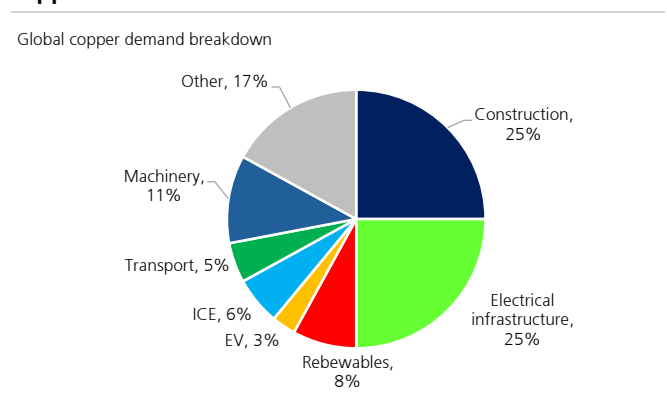
Gold imports mainly reflect financial investment demand. YTD gold imports surged 189% YoY and contributed over a quarter of total import growth. Chinese investment demand for gold typically follows price gains with a lag: as prices rose, demand for gold bars and coins increased 67% YoY in 1Q, helped by global uncertainty and elevated geopolitical tensions, while jewellery consumption fell YoY amid record-high prices. Strong 2Q price momentum may still provide near-term support, although it has softened. Note these figures refer to commercial gold imports and exclude direct central bank purchases, though some imports may later be acquired by the PBoC. Unlike retail investors, the PBoC tends to increase purchases when prices fall and slow the pace when prices surge (see [more](#)). Over the next 1-2 years, as gold price momentum fades, we expect domestic commercial demand to normalize. Imports of other precious metals, including silver, platinum, and precious-metal ores, have risen alongside gold, partly reflecting spillovers from higher gold prices.

Figure 9: Gold investment demand bounced in 1Q



Source: World Gold Council, Wind, UBS

Figure 10: Electrification trends can be a tailwind for copper demand



Source: WoodMac, UBS research

Upgrade 2026 trade forecasts

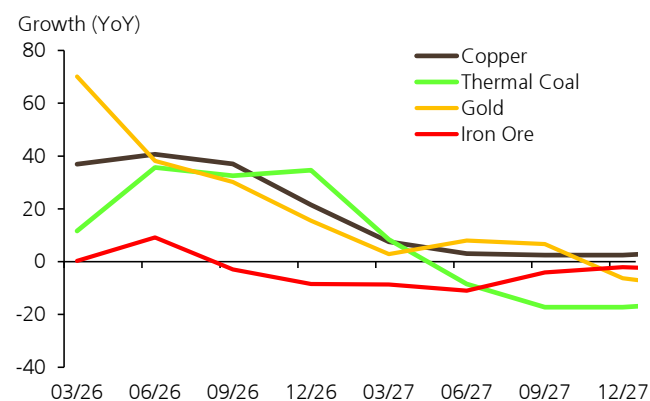
Prices remain a key swing factor for both exports and imports, especially in tech trade, where AI hardware and memory pricing matter more than end-demand volumes. We think the strongest sequential impulse in tech prices is now behind us. Tech export price level may still rise, while YoY growth may moderate later in the year. Meanwhile, our gold strategist expects prices to [rebound by year-end](#) and our global mining team remains [constructive on copper prices](#) given supply constraints and AI/energy demand. That said, the boost to YoY trade price is likely to wane. Iron ore prices, by contrast, are expected to trend lower in 2H, as it has less direct exposure to AI-related trade and Middle East-related disruptions.

In real terms, the trade slowdown was already clear in 2Q. Real export growth slowed to 7% YoY from 14% in 1Q, -21% QoQ Saar (vs 37% surge in 1Q), led by softer volumes in tech products—particularly computer components and electronic ICs—as well as traditional consumer goods, and ships. Real import growth also cooled sharply, slowing to 1% YoY in 2Q from 16% in 1Q and contracting 24% QoQ Saar after a 26% gain, mainly on weaker oil and tech imports.

Looking ahead, we expect both export and import value growth to lose momentum in 2H. AI-linked exports should remain resilient but grow at a slower pace, while green-transition products and autos should continue to support non-AI exports. Consumer goods are unlikely to rebound meaningfully, aside from a temporary heatwave-related lift to household appliances. On imports, AI-related processing trade and some policy support should help real demand recover from a weak 2Q, but softer price growth may cap its headline value growth.

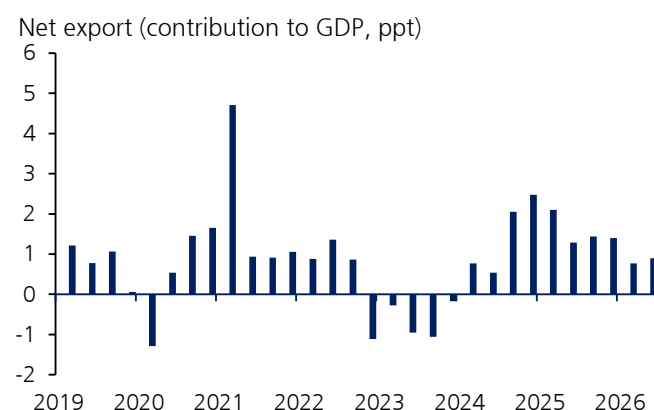
We upgrade our full-year 2026 trade forecasts. We now expect exports to grow 18% in nominal USD terms and imports 24%, well above our previous forecasts of 3% and 1.8%, respectively. Robust nominal trade figures do not automatically imply stronger GDP growth, as a large share of the increase has been price-driven. In real terms, we expect goods exports to grow 8-9% in 2026, down slightly from 9-10% in 2025, while imports should rise 7-8%, compared with roughly flat growth in 2025. We expect **net exports to contribute 0.8ppt to China's real GDP growth.** This is broadly in line with 1H reading and slightly higher than our previous forecast of 0.7ppt. Notedly, it's lower than the 1.6ppt contribution in 2025. The implication is straightforward: domestic demand will need to do more of the heavy lifting.

Figure 11: UBS expects commodity prices to decelerate in 2H 2026



Source: UBS

Figure 12: Net export contribution to GDP has been 0.8ppt in 1H vs 1.6ppt in 2025



Source: CEIC, UBS estimates

The key risk is the trajectory of the global AI cycle. A sharper pullback in tech capex would weigh on related exports, while stronger-than-expected capex or easing supply constraints could reshape demand. Because this AI trade cycle is more price-driven than a typical tech upcycle, prices of key AI inputs (particularly memory chips) will be critical to watch.

Beyond tech, trade policy remains the main external risk. Higher tariffs or tighter non-tariff measures would pose downside risks to exports. The latest shift to [Section 301 tariffs](#) is likely to have limited impact, but another Section 301 investigation related to excess capacity is still ongoing. The EU has also taken a tougher stance toward China, though concrete policy action remains unclear. Incremental trade barriers, geopolitical shocks, weaker global demand, or commodity price volatility could still weigh on exports at the margin. For imports, the key risk is softer domestic activity: if 2Q weakness persists, import volumes could undershoot expectations.

Macro and policy implications

Policy easing is warranted, but a property upswing remains unlikely. Strong exports have supported industrial production and created AI-related wealth effects in selected localities and industries, but the benefits remain concentrated in tech and export sectors. They are not enough to offset broader domestic headwinds, as reflected in the notable [slowdown in 2Q GDP growth](#). If 2Q momentum persists, full-year GDP growth would fall below the 4.5% lower bound of the target range. With imports set to outpace exports, net exports should provide a smaller boost to real GDP growth in 2026, highlighting the need to stabilize domestic growth.

Against this backdrop, we expect a meaningful easing signal at the upcoming Politburo meeting. Policy will likely focus on faster fiscal implementation, better coordination with monetary loosening, and continued support for infrastructure investment, especially the “six networks” (computing power, communication, water, power grid, logistics, and underground networks). Property support should remain aimed at stabilization rather than restarting a new upcycle, while additional consumption measures are likely to be relatively limited. This mix should be more supportive of copper, grid equipment, and selected industrial metals than bulk property-linked commodities. We believe a loosening tone on administrative measures and a more stable regulatory environment would also be important.

China's shifting trade mix is lifting export prices. After a cumulative decline of about 17% over three years, export prices rebounded 6.5% YoY in 1H, mainly driven by AI-related products and helped by domestic reflation. Because AI products likely account for a larger share of exports than of the PPI basket, and they are priced in tighter, globally integrated markets, export price inflation may prove more persistent than PPI and stay above PPI once oil-price shocks fade. Higher export prices could ease some deflation-export concerns, but may also add to global inflation, with the impulse concentrated in AI hardware and selected capital goods rather than broad consumer goods.

Worsening terms of trade have not stopped RMB appreciation. Import prices are rising faster than export prices, leading to deteriorating terms of trade. Typically, this would generate depreciation pressure. Yet the RMB appreciated against the dollar and the basket from mid-2025, partly reflecting lower geopolitical risks and a shift in market expectations. Reduced capital outflow pressure reinforced the move. The PBoC appears tolerant of RMB strength as long as appreciation is not rapid (see [here](#)), likely because a stronger currency helps ease trade frictions and signals confidence in China's export competitiveness. With exports increasingly driven by undersupplied AI products, they may also be less sensitive to exchange-rate moves than in previous cycles.

Looking into H2, the UBS FX team still expects the dollar to strengthen by ~2% (see [here](#)), which could weigh on USDCNY at the margin. We see two-way fluctuations in USDCNY in 2H: reduced geopolitical risks, lower outflow pressure and PBoC tolerance support the RMB, while weaker terms of trade, a potentially stronger USD and softer domestic demand should cap appreciation.

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